Bollywood films of the 1980s. One such was the Khan of a wandering horde of fire-worshipping Turks (Khan is a title predating Islam). Watched over by a bodyguard, the formidable Khan—clad in a green satin robe, his hair hanging loose—feasted on wine, veal and music in his lavish tent with his officers ‘clothed in brocade stuff’. Around them stood troops ‘mounted on camels and horses’, ‘clothed in furs and finespun hair garments’ and ‘carrying lances and bows and standards’. The Khan and his officers were filling each other’s cups with exhortations to drink more. As they became more boisterous, the music grew louder. The Khan then urged Xuanzang to abandon his pointless quest for that hot land of the Buddha, where men ‘are naked-blacks, without any sense of decorum, and not fit to look at!’

But Xuanzang was unstoppable and continued past Khotan, Tashkent and Samarkand, debating Buddhists on the Silk Road and in Afghanistan, where he saw the majestic Bamiyan Buddhas. At Takshashila, he saw Buddhism in decline, ruined monasteries and one of the 84,000 stupas built by Ashoka across India (it’s unclear how Xuanzang came up with that number), one that ‘constantly emits a sacred light from its surface’. At last, he had reached the subcontinent.

Xuanzang was away from China for seventeen years, spending thirteen of them in the subcontinent (630 –43 CE), travelling extensively and visiting the major sites associated with the Buddha’s life. He seemed to have had a deeply cathartic experience at the Bodhi tree under which the Buddha is said to have attained enlightenment, whose ‘leaves are heart-shaped, slender and pointed, and constantly quivering’.[11] Xuanzang learnt Sanskrit and studied for years with Buddhist masters, most notably at Nalanda, where he was under Silabhadra, a great master of the Yogacara school of Mahayana Buddhism, which Xuanzang had been drawn to from an early age. His erudition brought him great fame and royal patronage in India. In a convocation of religious scholars ‘in Harsha’s capital of Kannauj . . . Xuanzang allegedly defeated five hundred Brahmins, Jains, and heterodox Buddhists in spirited debate’.[12] In a flourish of religious humility, emperor Harsha even referred to himself as a servant of Xuanzang.[13]

Xuanzang gathered hundreds of Sanskrit texts, 150 relics of the Buddha, statues and other artefacts, loaded them on pack animals and returned the same way he had come. For the remaining nineteen years of his life at